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The psychological impact of disaster and community solidarity: A situational analysis of the mental well- being of Sri Lankans

Introduction

Mental well- being is defined as a state of emotional resilience that enables individuals to manage life's challenges effectively. For Sri Lankans, this stability is constantly tested by both systemic economic instability and recurrent natural disasters. The recent cyclone disasters and subsequent catastrophic flooding, which submerged vast areas of the Western, Northern, and Central provinces, represent a significant psychosocial stressor. This article critically explores the mental well-being of Sri Lankans during this crisis, focusing on the trauma of witnessing absolute loss and the role of community solidarity as a vital psychological buffer in the recovery process. It is important to recognize that such disasters create a "compounded trauma" where the fear of the physical event merges with long-term uncertainty about survival and stability.

The trauma of witnessing absolute loss and speciesism

Witnessing a disaster in real-life is a deeply distressing experience that leaves a lasting impact on the human psyche. Observations made during the recent floods highlighted rapid submersion of homes – primary 'safe spaces' that provide ontological security. The destruction of these environments often leads to a profound sense of displacement and 'place attachment' disruption. When a person's home-their most fundamental anchor is destroyed, the sense of self is often wounded, leading to a state of psychological fragmentation.

A particularly significant aspect of this trauma was the evident struggle of animals. It was a truly heartbreaking moment for me to see helpless animals like dogs tied up, struggling as the water rose so rapidly, was reported as a distressing experience for many survivors. Such moments evoke a deep sense of helplessness in onlookers. From a psychological perspective, this distress highlights the 'human-animal bond.' According to Fine (2019), witnessing trauma to animals can trigger secondary traumatic stresses in humans, reflecting a shared vulnerability that impacts the overall well-being of the community. The fear for survival combined with the helplessness of watching other living beings suffer, significantly elevates the risk of Acute Stress Disorder (ASD) among survivors. This shared sufferings reinforces the idea of

“ecological distress”, where the trauma of the environment and its creatures directly degrades human mental health.

Altruism and collective grief: A critical analysis of heroism

The rescue efforts by the Sri Lanka Army and Air Force provided more than physical safety; they offered a sense of ‘perceived security’ in a chaotic environment. As the water kept rising, the visibility of Air Force helicopters and Army boats arriving to save people trapped on roofs provide a sense of relief to the affected population. However, these operations also highlighted the psychological cost of heroism. The tragic death of wing commander Nirmal Siyambalapitiya in Lunuwila during a rescue mission created a state of ‘collective grief’ (Worden, 2018) across the nation. This loss serves as a true meaning of bravery, leaving a lasting impact on the national consciousness.

Critically, this event illustrates the concept of ‘prosocial altruism,’ where individuals risk their lives for the benefits of others. For those rescued, such sacrifices can lead to ‘survivor’s guilt,’ a complex psychological condition where individuals feel responsible for the safety they gained at the cost of another’s life. Acknowledging this sacrifice is not merely an act of remembrance but a crucial component of collective psychological healing and the restoration of social trust.

Communal coping as a resilience factor.

Despite the devastation in regions like Galle and Matara, the disaster revealed a robust ‘communal coping mechanism.’ There was an unprecedented mobilization of citizens providing food, clothing and transportation to flood victims. This collective action is a primary driver of ‘community resilience’. Another important aspect was psychology students from the Open University and many others bringing not just food, but also clothes and school books to help kids and adults who had lost everything in the water.

According to Silva & Perera (2024), Sri Lankan society often relies on informal social networks to buffer against the psychological impact of crises. This altruism serves as a protective factor against social isolation and depression. The realization that one is part of a supportive network provides the emotional reassurance necessary for individuals to begin the cognitive process of rebuilding their lives.

Psychosocial first aid: The role of academic institutions

The intervention by the Department of Psychology and Counselling at the Open University of Sri Lanka serves as a practical model for 'Psychological First Aid' (PFA). Their focus on children who lost educational materials addressed a specific form of 'future- oriented anxiety.' For a child, school supplies represent stability and a path to the future; their loss can lead to significant educational regression and long- term anxiety. By restoring these materials, the university community helped re-establish a sense of normalcy, which is a prerequisite for psychological recovery in post- disaster scenarios (Everly & Lating, 2022). By prioritizing the needs of children, academic institutions help prevent the development of developmental trauma, ensuring that the next generation is not permanently scarred by the crisis.

Conclusion

The recent floods have exerted a heavy toll on the mental well–being of Sri Lankans. Moreover, the crisis also demonstrated the power of resilience and solidarity. While the trauma of loss is profound, the combined efforts of the state, civil society, and academic institutions provide a pathway for recovery. For long-term national health, it is imperative that mental health support is integrated into disaster management policies, prioritizing psychological healing alongside physical reconstruction. Only through a holistic approach that treats mental health with the same urgency as physical infrastructure can Sri Lanka truly recover and stand strong against an uncertain climate future.

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